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Did God Really Say “Get Angry”?

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Did God Really Say “Get Angry”?

“Be angry, and do not sin.” (Ephesians 4:26, NKJV)

Many people use this verse to justify their anger saying that God instructs us to get angry and that we are not sinning if the other person is wrong and we are right. The problem with that line of thought is that we always think we are right and the other person is wrong. To understand the Ephesians verse properly we need to go to the original language that the verse was written in, Greek.

The Greek verb tense for “be angry” is a present passive imperative. Present means that it is happening right now. Passive means, that you take no action. Imperative is not a command to “get angry” but rather an acknowledgement that there are going to be times when you feel someone or something working on you to make you angry. Applying the present passive imperative verb tense means that as you become angry do not derive satisfaction from the anger, recognize that it is present, and do not act upon it. Be angered, but don’t sin by acting on your anger.

Didn’t Jesus get angry? Yes, in Mark 3:5, NAS 95: *After looking around at them with anger, grieved at their hardness of heart, He said to the man, “Stretch out your hand.” And he stretched it out, and his hand was restored.*

If all anger is sin, then Jesus sinned. But we know that Jesus did not sin or he would not be holy. How, then, was Jesus angry without sinning? Mark 3:5 is the only passage in the New Testament that uses the word “anger” with the person of Christ. However the word “grief” is also in that same verse. Jesus was angry at their sin and grieved at the condition of their hearts. Seldom does a person get angry at people and also become grieved over their condition at the same time. Jesus had that ability. God’s anger is never occasional, it is eternal. Jesus is eternally angry with sin and eternally forgiving toward sinners.

How do we experience anger and not sin? The same way Jesus experienced anger—if we are walking in union with Him and in the Holy Spirit—by not allowing the sun to go down on the anger nor allowing the devil a foothold. God states that anger is a part of our sinful nature and it is not listed as a fruit of the Holy Spirit. If we justify our anger as righteous because we are angry at the injustices in the world, we will

be angry all the time for we live in a unjust, fallen world. God instructs us in 1 Thessalonians 5:16-18, NAS95 to *Rejoice always; in everything give thanks, and we cannot do that if we are angry.*

The Bible clearly tells us that God sees anger as sin! Get rid of it!

Adapted from *Breaking Free from the Bondage of Sin*, Dr. Henry Brandt

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In Christ,

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